

Geertz's Symbolic Anthropology and Art as Cultural System

Clifford Geertz's interpretive anthropology treats **culture** as a "historically transmitted pattern of meanings embodied in symbols" ¹. In this view, **<Culture>** [is] "**a system of inherited conceptions expressed in symbolic forms**" ¹. For Geertz, **<Art>** is not an autonomous aesthetic realm but part of that symbolic system: he famously writes that "**Art is notoriously hard to talk about... it seems to exist in a world of its own, beyond the reach of discourse**" ², yet insists that we must grasp "**the meaning of things for the life that surrounds them**" ³. In *Art as a Cultural System*, Geertz argues that a work of art is a **symbolical expression of the significant experience of its creator** ⁴. In other words, **<Art>** [symbolizes] **<Experience>** – the creator's felt life – and art's perception depends on recognizing these cultural symbols ⁴. Thus for Geertz, aesthetic understanding is an interpretive act: **<Aesthetic perception>** [involves] **recognizing the symbols** contained in a work, a skill arising from participation in cultural practices ⁴. In Geertz's framework, **<Symbol>** [is a] "**vehicle of culture**" ¹, and art as a cultural system conveys worldview and values through these symbols.

Barthes: Semiotics, Myth, and the Textual Turn

Roland Barthes, in contrast, approaches art through semiology. Barthes sees cultural artifacts – including art and photography – as **signs** that operate in a *system of signification*. Each sign has a **denotation** (literal meaning) and a **connotation** (cultural implication). Barthes famously analyzed modern *mythologies*, showing how **<Myth>** [functions as] "**a second-order signifying system**" that naturalizes ideology ⁵. He observes that myth "makes 'itself look neutral and innocent' – it 'naturalises the concept and transforms history into nature'" ⁵. In Barthes's terms, an image or artwork is *read* rather than merely viewed. For example, in a photograph of a soldier saluting the flag (from his *Mythologies*), the denotation might be "youthful patriotism," while the connotative **mythic meaning** implies "France is a just empire," thereby justifying colonialism ⁵. In our notation: **<Myth>** [transforms] **<History>** into **<Nature>** ⁵, and **<Myth>** [serves] **<Ideology>** by emptying deeper historical context ⁵.



Figure: A photographer developing a print in a red-lit darkroom – evoking Barthes's emphasis on the photographic experience (the sensual punctum beyond cultural interpretation). Barthes's semiotic syntax treats **<Art>** [as] **"text"** to be decoded. In this schema, **<Signifier>** [carries] **<Signified>** and also a higher-level **<Myth>**. For Barthes, every artistic element can signify latent meaning within its cultural milieu. He encourages readers to look beyond the creator's intent: after all, "the birth of the reader" (and viewer) is achieved at "the cost of the death of the Author;" meaning interpretation is driven by how audiences receive art, not by authorial authority. In sum, Barthes's perspective maps art to **collective symbols**: **<Art>** [carries] **<denotation>** and **<connotation>**, where the latter often embeds social assumptions ⁵. Art is therefore an *ideological apparatus*: through myth it renders social values "common sense" ⁵.

Turner: Ritual, Performance, and Symbols in Process

Victor Turner, another symbolic anthropologist, emphasized **performance** and social action. Turner differed from Geertz: rather than seeing symbols as static culture-carriers, **<Turner>** [defines] **<symbols>** as **"operators in the social process"** ⁶. In Turner's model, symbols in art (especially ritual art) **instigate social action**: **<Symbols>** [instigate] **<social action>** ⁷. For example, a communal dance or drama isn't just a symbol of social order; it actively reshapes it. Turner analyzed rituals as *cultural performances* in which meaning is created in use. During a ritual or social drama, liminal symbols unite people and allow transformations: by their dramatic context they produce "social transformations" that resolve conflict or question norms ⁷. In our syntax, **<RitualPerformance>** [produces] **<Communitas>** (a communal bonding) and **<Transformation>** as participants enact shared stories. Turner even generalized ritual to modern art: a theater play or festival can be seen as a ritualized performance generating collective meaning. Thus Turner maps art to **process**: **<Artistic performance>** [is] a field of action where **<symbols>** [become] **<social interventions>** ⁷. His focus on the body is implicit: art is embodied participation, not just a text to be read.

Sontag: Sensory Experience Versus Interpretation

Susan Sontag sharply critiqued the interpretive impulse of thinkers like Geertz and Barthes. In "Against Interpretation," she argues that art's value lies in *what it is*, not hidden meanings: "the function of criticism should be to show how [art] **is what it is**, rather than to show what it means." Sontag famously declares that **"In place of a hermeneutics we need an erotics of art."** ⁸ In our terms, **<Sontag>** [advocates] an

erotics (bodily engagement) [over] a hermeneutic (textual decoding) approach. Sontag saw too much interpretation as poisonous: “the effusion of interpretations of art today *poisons our sensibilities*,” she writes ⁹. According to Sontag, **<Interpretation>** [is] a **reactionary assault** that “impoverish[es]” the world by constructing a “shadow world of meanings” ¹⁰. In her framework, art is a sensual event: **<Art>** [should be experienced] **<sensuously>** rather than analyzed for allegory. Her point is not that art has *no* meanings, but that the critic’s hunger for hidden content can strangle art’s immediate power.

Convergences and Divergences

These four thinkers converge in treating **<Art>** as embedded in culture, but diverge on emphasis. **Interpretation vs Experience:** Geertz and Barthes focus on decoding symbols – **<Art>** [exhibits] **<meaning>** within **<culture>** ⁴ ⁵. Turner also values meaning but through enactment: **<Art>** [functions as] **<social process>**. Sontag resists over-interpretation entirely: **<Interpretation>** [constricts] **<art>**, while **<Sensuous experience>** [liberates] it ⁸ ⁹. In effect, Geertz, Barthes, and Turner see **<Meaning>** as central, whereas Sontag urges we prioritize **<Sensation>** and form.

Role of the Body and Performance: Turner and Sontag give the body a key role. Turner treats ritual art as a living process: **<Body>** [is] a medium of cultural performance (communitas, liminality). Sontag emphasizes sensory, bodily reception (the *erotics* of seeing). Geertz and Barthes, by contrast, are more cerebral: they treat art as text or symbols to interpret. The former pair underscore community and collective action, the latter intellectual and semiotic structures.

Ideology and Culture: Barthes uniquely foregrounds ideology: **<Myth>** [reveals] **<power structures>** by naturalizing them ⁵. Geertz implicitly addresses ideology by studying how art expresses worldview. Turner, more pragmatic, sees art as mediating social tensions. Sontag, while less political, implicitly critiques ideology in art by exposing how intellectualism (a kind of ideology) can suffocate authentic experience ⁹.

Author, Text, Ritual: Barthes replaces the author with the reader/spectator (“death of the Author”), while Geertz “reads” the artist’s cultural text (knowing the creator’s context). Turner is less concerned with authorial intent or text; he cares about participants’ shared enactment. Sontag, ironically, also downplays the artist in favor of viewer response, but without Barthes’s structural codings.

Synthesis: Layered Meanings in Art as Cultural System

Together, these views suggest a richly layered model of art. One can map **<Art>** as a “**system of cultural meaning**” where multiple channels operate in parallel. Geertz and Barthes invite us to perform “thick interpretation”: **<Art>** [is read as] **<symbolic text>** ⁴ ⁵. In this layer, art encodes shared symbols: for Geertz, the creator’s experience; for Barthes, the culture’s myths. Turner invites an additional layer: art as performance or **process**. Here **<Art>** [is] **<social action>**, enacted and felt together, generating meaning in use ⁶. Finally, Sontag reminds us of a **sensory layer**: **<Art>** [is also] **<immediate experience>**. This level resists hermeneutics – it is about how the work feels, moves, or shocks the body.

In categorical terms, we can view **<Art>** as a multi-faceted **object** linked by morphisms to different conceptual objects. For example: - **<Art>** [symbolizes] **<Experience>** (Geertz) and **<Art>** [carries] **<Myth>** (Barthes). - **<Art>** [instantiates] **<Communitas>** (Turner) and **<Art>**

[elicits] <SensoryResponse> (Sontag). - <Interpretation> [mediates] <Art> in Geertz and Barthes, whereas <Erotics> [mediates] <Art> in Sontag.

By layering these mappings, we see that art operates simultaneously as text, ritual, and sensory field. Geertz's diagnostic suggestion – "a science which can determine the meaning of things for the life that surrounds them" ³ – can be reimagined: we need a multi-modal hermeneutics. For instance, a single artwork can be read for mythic symbols (Barthes), contextualized in creator and audience culture (Geertz), enacted in performance (Turner), and viscerally experienced (Sontag).

Example Integration: Consider a public mural. A Geertzian reading might identify how it encodes local history and values. A Barthesian reading might reveal how its imagery naturalizes certain political narratives as "common sense." A Turner-inspired view might study the mural's unveiling ceremony as a communal event that temporarily suspends normal social order. A Sontagian view would attend to the immediate visual impact and emotional reaction, cautioning against burying that in abstract interpretation. Each perspective adds a layer of meaning: the mural is simultaneously a cultural text, a ritual focal point, and an aesthetic spectacle.

In conclusion, Geertz, Barthes, Turner, and Sontag offer **complementary lenses** on art-as-cultural-system. Geertz provides the broad framework of culture as symbolic webs ⁴; Barthes decodes the semiotics and ideology of cultural images ⁵; Turner emphasizes dynamic performance and social enactment ⁶; and Sontag rekindles attention to sensuous experience and warns against interpretive excess ¹⁰ ⁸. When combined, these approaches suggest that art in culture is both made and remade through symbols, rituals, and sensations. Integrating them means reading art as *thickly meaningful*: every artwork is an intersection of symbolic system, performer-audience interaction, and immediate sensation. This rich integration equips us to see art not just as reflection or commentary, but as an **active system of cultural life** – exactly the vision Geertz hoped for, achieved by interweaving semiotic, performative, and aesthetic threads ⁴ ¹⁰.

Sources: Geertz's symbolic anthropology and *Art as a Cultural System* ¹ ⁴; Barthes's semiotic and myth analyses ⁵; Turner on symbols and performance ⁶; Sontag's *Against Interpretation* ¹⁰ ⁸. Each provides a "morphism" mapping art to meaning, performance, or sensation in the cultural matrix.

¹ ⁶ ⁷ Symbolic and Interpretive Anthropologies – Anthropology

<https://anthropology.ua.edu/theory/symbolic-and-interpretive-anthropologies/>

² ³ Challenging Art as Cultural Systems . . . for Cliff from the Twenty-First Century: Light Shows, Shadow Plays, Pressure Points | Society for Cultural Anthropology

<https://culanth.org/fieldsights/challenging-art-as-cultural-systems>

⁴ Art as a Cultural System : The Russian Sociological Review

<http://sociologica.hse.ru/en/2010-9-2/27371436.html>

⁵ Roland Barthes' Concept of Mythologies – Literary Theory and Criticism

<https://literariness.org/2016/03/21/roland-barthes-concept-of-mythologies/>

⁸ ⁹ ¹⁰ Microsoft Word - Against Interpretation.doc

<https://static1.squarespace.com/static/54889e73e4b0a2c1f9891289/t/564b6702e4b022509140783b/1447782146111/Sontag-Against+Interpretation.pdf>